Seapower in South India' by one V.V. Rajaratnam from Point Calimere. Pointing out that the maritime spirit in the region had only recently been awakened, he noted with pain that neither of the two indigenous steamship companies—the Madras Steam Navigation Company and the Swadeshi Steam Navigation Comapany—had 'as yet attained any success'. But the article was full of platitudes: any concern without 'real and zealous combination of wealth and practical knowledge will ultimately prove unsuccessful' and warned that failed efforts would injure 'not only its shareholders but the prospect of financial support to any real promising business of the future'. More patronizingly, he said, 'A little more foresight and calm discretion would have brought about a crowning success to the Tuticorin Swadeshi Steam Navigation Co. Ltd. Instead of placing too much confidence in the support of their countrymen and in getting the overestimated profits, its promoters might have usefully bestowed their consideration on the opposing forces and to unforeseen difficulties.' And as if to rub it in, he went further: 'In order to succeed in any business in this country, one should discreetly direct oneself clear of politics and if once the commercial vessel came in contact with the dangerous political rock, it is certain to be wrecked, possibly drowning the persons on board.' Clearly, the writer had no clue to the motivations of VOC—for whom SSNCo was primarily a political project. Such gratuitous advice provided cold comfort to those facing the brunt of colonial state power and British maritime might. This was precisely the line taken by the ruling faction within SSNCo who had dethroned VOC. Rajaratnam's proffered solution was no more practical: he argued that 'the wisest course' was to amalgamate the two drowning shipping concerns into a big company. Towards this end he appended four schedules of calculations—all academic with no relation to reality.[89]

Similarly, in reproducing S.D. Krishna Aiyangar's appeal of 16 December 1909, the editor of the Dalit monthly *Booloka Vyasan*, Pooncholai Muthuveera Navalar, struck a note of caution in endorsing the call for contributions to SSNCo. While it was imperative that the benefits of indigenous enterprise should be reaped by properly watering and manuring